

Barring three or four hospitals, most have either failed to take off or have floundered. Financial crunch, mismanagement and failure to attract qualified doctors and paramedical staff are the prime reasons for their sickness. "Much of it is an ill-planned charity which has only created white elephants," says Sukhdev Singh, director of the NRI Sabha—a Jalandhar-based NGO: "Such hospitals are suffer-

ing from want of regular resources." 30, is illiterate and has no clue how to resuscitate the abandoned project, though he is now in the UK to raise more funds. "Money is not a problem. Babaji is looking for educated locals and doctors to run the project but they prefer to migrate abroad," says Sonu, a dera caretaker. There is also a plan to convert the half-built complex into a school or a sewing training centre.

In fact, a competition of sorts among the expatriates for funding



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ing from want of regular resources."

The NRI benevolence has gone awry particularly in the projects initiated by babas who have followers among the expatriates hailing from their area. Being illiterate, they are clueless on managing multi-crore projects. Take, for instance, the Guru Nanak Nirmal Charitable Hospital spread over 14 acre and built by Sant Moniji, head of Nirmal Kutia dera in Pandava, a sleepy village about 13 km from Phagwara. His followers in Canada, the US and the UK donated liberally for the 500-bed super-speciality hospital which the baba had claimed would be as state-of-the-art as the Post-Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research in Chandigarh and cater to over a hundred villages. However, after an expenditure of a whopping Rs 8 crore, the sprawling three-storey building looks like a house occupied by ghosts today. For the work on the Rs 13-crore project was suspended five years ago, soon after the baba died and the local management committee witnessed a split. His successor, Baba Gurcharan Singh,

▲ **HOSPITAL:** Bhagat Hari Singh Charitable Hospital **Started by** A trust floated by a UK-based Sikh sect in '99

LOCATION: DADIYAL VILLAGE, HOSHIARPUR

MONEY SPENT: Rs 4 crore

STATUS: Half-built, runs only an OPD

WHO'S TO BLAME: Paucity of funds due to death of the sect head

subsidised healthcare in their native places has led to mushrooming of such hospitals in small pockets. For instance, apart from the still-to-be-born hospital project at Pandava, three NRI-run hospitals have come up in the nearby villages of Rurka Kalan, Pasla and Bilga—all within a radius of 10 km. Built with an investment of Rs 30 crore in the last decade or so, their infrastructure is grossly underutilised for want of patients.

Indeed, most of the NRI-managed hospitals have proved to be non-starters because of their ill-conceived locations. "They are driven more by nostalgia than by need," says Budh Singh, a Canadian citizen who has

THE OTHERS IN TROUBLE

Hospital: Bilga General Hospital
Started by Bilga General Hospital Charitable Trust floated by natives in Britain
Location: BILGA, NEAR PHILLAUR
Money spent: Rs 20 crore
Status: Commissioned in 2005, but grossly under-utilised
Who's to blame: Administrative problems and lack of doctors

Hospital: Guru Nanak Dev Charitable Hospital
Started by Birmingham-based Guru Nanak Nishkam Sewak Jatha
Location: GURA VILLAGE, NEAR PHILLAUR
Money spent: Rs 2 crore
Status: Building completed in 1995, but shut since then
Who's to blame: Lack of doctors, and the apathy of locals

Hospital: Guru Nanak Dev Charitable Hospital
Started by Native NRIs in London, hospital commissioned in 2002
Location: PASLA
Money spent: Rs 3 crore
Status: Under-utilised, incurring losses
Who's to blame: Local committee unable to run the hospital

Hospital: Bhai Sadhu Charitable Hospital
Started by A trust floated by villagers, NRIs. Commissioned in 2002
Location: NEAR PASLA
Money spent: Rs 1.5 crore
Status: Runs only a skeletal OPD
Who's to blame: No doctor, funds crunch

Hospital: Jasbir Singh Memorial Hospital
Started by US-based Jasbir Singh Memorial Society; commissioned in 2005
Location: VAJDIPUR VILLAGE, NAWANSHAHR
Money spent: Rs 2 crore
Status: In the red, running a skeletal OPD
Who's to blame: No doctor, funds crunch

been running the biggest and the most successful NRI-funded charitable hospital at Dhahan Kaleran on the Chandigarh-Jalandhar highway. His ingenious model has inspired many other first-generation immigrants from the Doaba region to go on a hospital-building spree in their ancestral villages, but with little success.

Far from being a lifeline for the rural folk who are still dependent on appallingly poor government health services, the hospitals have become a liability for their foreign-based trusts which are finding it difficult to run them. "It's easy to raise donations abroad for a charitable hospital back home, but a lot harder to run it," says